Personal Statement

Rhea Choudhary
UC Berkeley

When I was about eight years old, my parents decided to move from the Middle East to Australia to secure a better and brighter future for me and my brother. However, my dad struggled to find work once we got there, so my parents made the tough decision to live separately – my mum with my brother and I in Australia, and my dad overseas. For almost two decades, my mum effectively functioned as a single parent and I watched as she pulled every string at her disposal to give us the future they so desperately wanted for us. Back in the Middle East, my dad worked long hours to send us money and afford a few trips a year to visit, including a special trip for my 16th birthday, an occassion he usually had to miss.

As I look back on my high school and university experiences, I think a lot about how important my family and the informal safety net they provided was to my academic and professional journey. I could take risks in my career, take on more study or choose more demanding professional roles in large part because I had informal support. But I also think a lot about how getting through the door to these opportunities required government support; I went to a public university, used government-issued university loans, and relied income assistance when studying full-time. In this way, both government assistance and family support played complementary roles in helping my career. But I've also seen examples where both fall short. For instance, I watched as my brother was unemployed for over three years and needed more than just the imperfect income assistance provided by unemployment insurance. Job-search in fields like IT and computer science, which is his specialisation, is incredibily challenging because the nature of these jobs are rapidly changing to due AI. Government programs aren't well-positioned to alleviate labour-market scarring in the face of such technological disruption. And informal support can only go so far – moral support and encouragement from my parents can often be viewed as patronising or insensitive, and financial support to wedge the gap that unemployment insurance creates can only last so long. Like most young Australians, he is college educated, so mutual obligation requirements that encourage short-term courses didn't work for him.

These experiences have strongly motivated my decision to pursue graduate study, because I want to answer important questions like these that are front-of-mind within the academic community as well as in policymaking. I want to grow my knowledge set on key developments and techniques in the literature, and eventually push the frontier of the discipline to answer questions of deep importance to me.

[Leadership, community outreach or service experience.]

I believe the combination of my personal background and my professional experience, both through my predoctoral research and in policymaking, would deliver valuable contributions to UC Berkeley's community. For instance, [xxx]

[Berkeley-specific: how my perspectives and aspirations align with UC Berkeley's Principles of Community.]

Word count: 475